

If someone would to ask if AI/Ai art is harming the environment and wasting water. What is the best answer to oppose if there is?

Posted by u/Pale-Bookkeeper-8117 • • 0 points • 29 comments

And I'm not talking like

"Water cycle"

or

"Social media uses water too and we're using it too"

I mean like THE BEST rebuttal or answer for this response that AI is doing wrong on our Earth.

But... If AI really showed that it does harm to the environment (lets just say), what are the solutions to all of this? Should we dismantle or re-built a way to use AI but with more environment friendly solutions.

Btw I decided to post this here than r/aiwars cause that place is one debating hellhole. I want to hear your guys thoughts on a actual Pro Ai subreddit without the divisive left and right. Thx!

Also, I like to research about AI. I get that people hate it but I am a bit skeptical.

Comments

u/karamanidturk • 1 points • 2026-01-26 23:16 UTC

What can take a lot of energy is ****training**** an image generator model. ****Not using**** it, like you and I and anyone else would. Generating an AI image costs less energy than stuff like playing an online videogame or streaming video. The people who try to use the environment card are usually full of shit though, they don't actually care.

u/Smooth-Marionberry • 1 points • 2026-01-17 04:33 UTC

Here's some good links with simplified research.

<https://andymasley.substack.com/p/the-ai-water-issue-is-fake>

<https://blog.giovanh.com/blog/2024/08/18/is-ai-eating-all-the-energy-part-1-of-2/>

<https://blog.giovanh.com/blog/2024/09/09/is-ai-eating-all-the-energy-part-2-of-2/>

<https://blog.giovanh.com/blog/2025/04/03/why-training-ai-cant-be-ip-theft/>

https://youtu.be/H_c6MWk7PQc?si=w2NZziilfLMLK5Nx

u/Pale-Bookkeeper-8117 • 2 points • 2026-01-18 19:06 UTC

will look out. thx

u/sammoga123 • 1 points • 2026-01-17 01:11 UTC

The reason AI needs so many resources, even though people still don't seem to care, even after I explain it to them in simple terms that AI doesn't steal, as I already did with a mini-comic this week.

Basically, AI isn't a single algorithm; it's a set of algorithms that together are capable of learning. And well, the math involved isn't so easy for a human to do, much less for a GPU with 4 GB of RAM from 2014.

Processing img x1je2hib8tdg1...

This is an example of the math applied in an artificial neural network. Obviously, it's only a part (the paper is about Qwen Image, and Qwen Image edit), but you can more or less see that the math is complex and that computation time is obviously needed depending on the architecture used.

Regarding cooling, it's as basic as saying that everything generates heat in the end. Your local PC only needs cooling from a fan, but if you have thousands of PCs (which is basically what a server is, a PC dedicated to online traffic), putting a fan on all of them isn't very reliable for cooling them down before everything overheats. And obviously, any website needs data centers; it's not like Reddit and other social networks literally run in the "cloud" and God cools them down with his breath XD.

u/Chaghatai • 1 points • 2026-01-16 22:03 UTC

Modern data centers use recirculating water and generally draw it from non-potable sources

Like many technologies, it has gotten more efficient over time and is continuing to do so

And it is a good argument to point out hypocrisy—if someone is complaining about AI water use but has been silent about the American lawn and golf courses, social media, video streaming, and MMOs, then it just shows that they're using it as a blunt object against ai and not that they really care about water usage

u/3ChainsOGold • 1 points • 2026-01-16 18:34 UTC

Individual consumers can do approximately nothing on their own to head off environmental catastrophe.

Without the corporations and nation-states fully on board, we're boned.

It's obscene that they've made us feel guilty about throwing trash in a trash can, but it's a good distraction while they go right on doing whatever they want.

u/No-Age-1044 • 1 points • 2026-01-16 18:22 UTC

Burger

u/AustinBeeman • 2 points • 2026-01-16 15:55 UTC

The problem is that anti-AI people are coming to the conversation with a core assumption that any AI use of water is too much. The way to handle the debate is to throw back on them how much water is appropriate for AI use? If they say no amount of water, then you were dealing with a radical that cannot be talked to, only defeated. You can also ask them to make specific claims that you can later debunk. But the first question is the one to find out whether you are dealing with someone who can be talked to.

u/duckduckduckgoose8 • 1 points • 2026-01-21 05:34 UTC

Brilliant response. Water is used in so many processes. Calling them out by asking how much they expect is a great way of weeding out the parrots that are just repeating what the masses told them to be outraged about.

u/Ready_Yam4471 • 1 points • 2026-01-16 15:46 UTC

I would acknowledge that AI requires massive computation compared to eg plain webbrowsing. This doesn't make it bad by default. It is just a fact and a downside of the technology. But the upsides outweigh it, and the potential is huge, thats why a global arms race to push it forward started. And depending on the use-case and model size the computation to handle a request after training isn't even that bad.

But giving cheap and easy access to billions of monkeys who use a costly technology for casual chatting and non-productive fun tasks without considering the impact is the real problem. Creating a service for fun slop content creation is bad, if the actual cost of the computation and environmental impact is not factored into the price at all.

But thats just how the economy we live in works right now. Don't blame the tech, blame the system that operates it in a wasteful and capitalist way. Demonizing the tech by default won't help. If you want to save the earth, like with any other product in our global industry, don't blame others for using it and look at yourself. Try to reduce your own impact and be responsible with the things and companies you support with your wallet. That's the best you can do. Being a virtue signaling know-it-all about whatever topic is trendy right now has never changed anyone's opinion.

u/RagingFeverDream • 1 points • 2026-01-16 14:26 UTC

I usually just say something along the lines of "if this is truly about potable water usage, then we can advocate for more incentives and regulations for companies to use waterless cooling centers."

u/Herr_Drosselmeyer • 1 points • 2026-01-16 13:20 UTC

>**Major Sectors & Their Usage (Based on 2015 USGS Data)**

>**Thermoelectric Power (41%):** Water used for cooling power plants, a massive withdrawal but often returned after use.

>**Irrigation (37%):** For crops, supporting significant agricultural output, though much is lost to evaporation.

>**Public Supply (12%):** For homes, businesses, schools, and hospitals, delivered via municipal

systems.

> **Industrial (5%):** Manufacturing, food processing, chemicals, etc., with significant water needs.

> **Other (5%):** Includes aquaculture, mining, and domestic self-supply.

> **Key Distinctions**

> **Withdrawals vs. Consumption:** Thermoelectric power has huge withdrawals but low consumption (water is returned); agriculture has high withdrawals and very high consumption (water is used up by plants).

> **Household Use:** A typical family uses 400 gallons/day, with 70% indoors (showers, toilets, etc.) and 30% outdoors (lawns).

So, we're looking at industrial use. Let's be generous, and say that data centers make up a fifth of industrial use (they don't). Even then, that's 1% of water usage with high rates of return. Basically, it's not a major factor.

u/CMDRTornadopelt • 1 points • 2026-01-16 13:01 UTC

First, let's set the record straight.

ChatGPT alone use .32 mL of water per query, straight from Sam Altman's mouth. For an entire liter, that's 3,125 queries. For a gallon, 11,830 queries.

ChatGPT processes 2.5 billion prompts/queries a day, for 211,327 gallons consumed daily. For reference, that's not even enough to fill 1/3 of an Olympic swimming pool, and absolutely **pathetic** when compared to other water-using activities. For example...

Walt Disney World uses approx. 100 TIMES more water than what ChatGPT does per day. One resort VS the entire global use of ChatGPT, at 21.9 million gallons per day.

A hamburger costs 660 gallons of water to make. McDonald's sells 6.5 million burgers a day. By the 320th burger, they've already exceeded the sum total cost of ChatGPT. And they sell, on average, 75 burgers a SECOND. After five seconds on any given day, McDonald's will have used the same equivalent water cost as ChatGPT, totalling 4.29 billion gallons per day - 20,000 times MORE than ChatGPT.

The average golf course uses 300,000 gallons per day, and there are 38,000 golf courses around the world. This totals 11.4 billion gallons per day, for about 54,000 times ChatGPT's usage.

The Bamu River is at the bottom of a ranked list of 175 rivers, ranked on water discharge volume. The Bamu River discharges 528,344 gallons of water per SECOND into the ocean. 2.5 times ChatGPT's volume of water consumed per DAY, discharged in A second.

u/Jefari_MoL • 1 points • 2026-01-16 16:47 UTC

It seems when you start talking in large numbers, the average reaction is "big number bad." What they don't understand is when you are talking on a global scale, a couple million gallons is a drop in a bucket.

u/CMDRTornadopelt • 1 points • 2026-01-16 21:27 UTC

Here's another angle.

If you were to skip a single hamburger, you could make one query on ChatGPT per day for the next 21,376.6 **years.**

u/No_Theme_2907 • 3 points • 2026-01-16 11:51 UTC

Personally, the conclusion I have come to is that it is nowhere near as bad as the anti stance says, on the other hand, it isn't an irrelevant amount either. Hank Green on YouTube had a good video (title: why is everyone so wrong about ai water use) that covers the broad intro of the topic.

This conversation also usually overlooks local deployment.
Other industries can use a lot more water.

Although it is typically not as intensive on the physical hardware, literally every online service needs a datacenter, some is GPU compute and some is not.

I absolutely believe that there are people who genuinely care about water use, and the role AI has in it, and that they also may or may not be correct in the estimated amount used.

But, I think there is a lot of influence and activity that is being used to create a divide between society/everyday people, this isn't just the narrative/story itself, but the anger/hate that is a part of that. Most people don't want the environment to be damaged (what that means for one person can be very different for another).

Bob in marketing asking an LLM about movie recommendations isn't going to be the issue, corporations and powerful people that do whatever they want essentially, and which also benefit from a divided and misguided society on the other hand 🤔

All of this above is subjective or personal opinion.

EDIT: also, my above comment has nothing to do with a personal stance of the subreddit topic, it popped up on my feed and I commented in response to the post without knowing the subreddit.

u/Tyrthemis • 2 points • 2026-01-16 11:31 UTC

First off, making the data centers draw from renewable and carbon neutral resources is essential no matter what this argument turns out to be. As far as water goes, they need a lot to work with and that lowers the water table essentially. Water filtration plants can only make so much potable water so quickly, if a data center is chugging through that, local water begins to feel like a more finite resource.

What we can do to mitigate the water use is passive cooling and build them in areas where water is plentiful, not the desert. Or we can have air conditioned cooling instead of water cooling. Better yet, if we make data centers where it's really cold, we can use the waste heat to heat homes.

Meta got busted for contaminating water near one of their data centers, so this is definitely something to watch out for and prevent. Last thing we need is a more polluted planet, especially forever chemicals.

u/[deleted] • 1 points • 2026-01-16 11:29 UTC

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u/OGRITHIK • 1 points • 2026-01-16 11:18 UTC

A single piece of paper consumes around 10 liters of water, that is as much as 256 to 27,027 ChatGPT prompts (0.37mL and 39mL as efficient and worst case for this)

u/see-more_options • 1 points • 2026-01-16 11:08 UTC

People do not hate AI. Some people do, but they do not speak for all.

AI computation is computation. There is no difference. This is the only rebuttal, everything else is just succumbing to bad faith fallacies. The 'AI data center' is just a data center. Same as we had for decades. That's it.